

Opinion Editor Onboarding Guide

The Daily Gamecock

J.C. Vaught

Last updated: January 2026

1. Accounts & Access

You need two logins:

Service	Purpose	Notes
CEO3	Article writing, previewing, adding titles/authors, managing publication workflow	Get credentials from outgoing editor or EIC
Slack	All editorial communication, budgeting, handoffs	Sign up with your USC <code>@mailbox.sc.edu</code> email rather than <code>@email.sc.edu</code>

No other tools are strictly required. Most editors use **Google Docs** for drafting and collaboration.

2. First Reading

Start with **Opinion_Editing_Handbook** (in this same onboarding folder) — it covers editorial policy and training specific to your role.

The other documents in the style guides folder (**DG_Headlines**, **Writer_Resources**, **DG_statements**) are general advice useful for all writers and worth reading when you have time, but not urgent.

3. Slack Channels

You should be added to the following channels:

3.1. Core Channels

Channel	Who's In It	Purpose
tdg-opinion	All opinion writers, managing editors	Main opinion section chat

tdg-opinionteam	Managing editors, EIC, opinion leaders, Creative Director	Opinion leadership coordination
tdg-opinionmultimedia-20XX	Artists, photographers, illustrators	Visuals for opinion section (name updates yearly)

3.2. Cross-Section Channels

Channel	Purpose
tdg-artsopinion	Arts & Culture leaders + Opinion leaders
tdg-newsopinion	News leaders + Opinion leaders
tdg-sportsopinion	Sports leaders + Opinion leaders

3.3. Organization-Wide Channels

Channel	Who's In It	Purpose
tdg-fullstaff	Every TDG member	General announcements
tdg-seniorstaff	All section leaders/editors + beat writers (paid staff)	Leadership coordination; contains the Budget sheet in bookmarks
#ready-for-editing	All section leaders	Post when a piece is ready for the next stage

4. The Budget Sheet

The Budget is a **Google Sheet** found in the **bookmarks** at the top of the **tdg-seniorstaff** channel.

4.1. Columns You Use

Column	Format / Notes
Story	(Opinion) Column: TITLE HERE — always prefix with your section
Author	Writer's name
Status	Current stage: <i>In writing</i> , <i>Up for section editors</i> , <i>Up for copy</i> , etc.

4.2. Color Coding

- **Yellow** — on schedule / standard
- **Red** — pushed, delayed, or cancelled

Add articles **at least 7 days** before the target publication date to give Copy and Design enough lead time.

5. CEO3 (SNworks) — Article Management

5.1. Getting Started

1. **Log in** at <https://ceo3.getsnworks.com>
 - Username: sagckopinion@mailbox.sc.edu
 - Password: Opinion1908
 - Select **CEO3** if prompted (CEO2 is deprecated).
2. Click **New** → **New Article** to create a piece.
3. To find an existing article, use the **search bar** and type the article name.

5.2. Setting Up an Article

- **Title:** Format as Column: headline headline
- **Slug:** Format as column-headline-headline-author_name
- **Tag:** Set an Opinion tag.
- **Author:** Set the writer as author.
- **Status:** Set to match the current stage (mirrors the Budget sheet).
- **Abstract:** Click the Abstract field to set the **subheading** (2-sentence summary).
- **Meta tab:**
 - **Infobox** — set pull quotes here.
 - **Social media summary** — set here as well (Twitter/Instagram-length).

5.3. Editing in CEO3

Action	How
Add hyperlink	Select text, then Cmd+K (Mac) or Ctrl+K (Windows)
Leave a comment for Copy	Select text, click the Comment button, write your note (e.g., “Source for this claim is in recording ABC”)
Leave a comment for the writer	Write bold inline text within the article body, or add a bold paragraph . Optionally sign with your initials (e.g., -JC).
Preview	Click the Preview button at the top

5.4. Saving & Checking In/Out

- **Save and Check In** — saves the article and locks it (you’re done editing for now)
- **Check Out** — re-opens the article for further editing

6. Standard Workflow

6.1. Idea to Budget (Pre-editing)

1. **Idea surfaces** — could come from a writer, from you, or from pitch meetings.
2. **Add to the Budget** — add the piece to the Budget sheet in `tdg-seniorstaff` at least 7 days before target pub date.
3. **Submit a Visuals Form** — this is a workflow in the Senior Staff Slack channel. Ask the writer if they have any specific visual ideas before submitting.

6.2. Editing (in CEO3)

We assume the writer knows how to use CEO and has already uploaded their draft. Edit in this order of priority:

Priority Check		Details
A	Factuality	Verify all sources. Do not accept Wikipedia. If a source is not available online, leave a comment in CEO for the Copy desk to verify behind you.
B	AP Style	Ensure general AP Style compliance. Opinion pieces have some flexibility, but the basics should be followed.
C	Opinion consistency	Watch for the thesis drifting mid-piece. If it shifts, clarify with the writer.
D	Readability (optional)	Would a person actually want to read this, or is it dry?
E	Add metadata	Add: subhead (abstract), social media summary (Meta tab), pull quote in the Infobox (if applicable). Sometimes add SEO headline and summary.

6.3. Giving Feedback to Writers

You will typically give feedback **twice**:

1. **First pass** — write inline comments in CEO (bold text, optionally signed with initials) or do full rewrites of problem sections. See `Opinion Editing Handbook` for comment formatting.
2. **Second pass** — check in the article and message the writer about remaining changes.

6.4. Handoff to Copy

1. **Check in** the piece in CEO (save and exit).
2. **Update the Budget** — change the article's status in the Google Sheet.
3. **Notify Copy** — post in `#ready-for-editing`, e.g.:
Column: Article Title is ready for @copy

4. **Wait** for feedback from Copy and Design.

6.5. After Copy Review

- Copy will reach out to **you and the writer** if they have additional concerns.
- Fix as many issues as you can yourself so the writer has less to deal with. The split is at your discretion.
- Often Copy will not require another review if the piece is clean.
- If you need to make **last-minute changes**, let Copy know ASAP so you can coordinate.

7. Edge Cases

7.1. Guest Columns

- **Less strict** overall: relaxed AP Style, less pressure on opinion consistency and readability.
- **Factuality still applies fully** — verify sources the same way.
- **Shorter timeline** for visuals, but you still must submit a Visuals Form. Guest columns use a **standardized image** (no custom illustration).
- Pull quote is always **optional**.

7.2. Fast-Track Columns

For breaking or time-sensitive events (e.g., a death, mass shooting):

- Talk to the **Editor-in-Chief** to approve an accelerated timeline.
- Expect **no illustrations** — only simple images.
- Visuals Form may not be needed; coordination will happen by word of mouth.

7.3. Pushed (Delayed) Columns

If a piece needs to be delayed:

1. In the Budget sheet, add the text **PUSHED** (bold) before the article title.
2. Change the cell color to **red**.
3. Move the entry to the **bottom** of the Budget sheet.

When rescheduling:

- Add the article to its **new date** in the Budget.
- Do **not** write “PUSHED” next to the rescheduled entry.
- Use the **standard yellow** cell coloring.

If a piece is **cancelled**: leave it as PUSHED and simply do not re-add it to the calendar.

8. Publication Schedule

- Opinion publishes on **Wednesday** and **Friday**.
- Minimum **1 piece per day** on each of those days.
- Pieces can be either regular columns or guest columns.
- Guest columns are preferred when possible — they can be received and published within a **2-day window** versus the **8–9 day window** for regular columns.

9. Recruiting Writers

- The Daily Gamecock holds **pitch meetings** organized centrally. You may only get notice about a day beforehand.
- For recruiting, **prioritize prior guest columnists** over brand-new writers. They already know the process and have demonstrated they can deliver.

10. Approval Chain

The full approval pipeline for a piece:

Writer → Assistant Editor → Editor → Copy → Managing Editor → EIC → Photo & Design

10.1. Key People to Know

- **Your writers** — you work with them most directly
- **Copy desk** — they review everything after you; maintain a good relationship
- **Managing Editor** — approves pieces after Copy; your direct report in the chain
- **Design lead** — coordinates visuals and illustrations for your pieces
- **Editor-in-Chief** — final editorial authority; go to them for fast-track approvals and escalations

11. Common Pitfalls

Don't dilute the voice. The most common mistake new opinion editors make is playing it too safe — softening a writer's raw emotion until the piece loses its punch. Your job is not to neutralize the opinion. Your job is to **channel and amplify** it while keeping the piece legally safe.

The goal is to preserve the writer's conviction while ensuring the language is protected opinion rather than stated fact. When in doubt, reframe claims as clearly rhetorical rather than removing them.

12. Legal & University Review

- **SNworks** is only the platform host — they have no editorial role.
- **The university** generally does not intervene unless:
 1. Someone **complains** about a published piece, OR
 2. You are **writing about USC itself** (e.g., “USC is letting nazis speak on campus”). The university will require you to **get a statement from them** before publication.
- **DG legal review**: If a piece is particularly aggressive or legally risky, the **Editor-in-Chief** may send it to legal. This is the EIC’s call, not yours.

13. Writer Deadlines

- **Idea on the Budget** — at least 7–8 days before publication
- **Draft submitted** — at least 3 days before publication (2 days absolute worst case)

If a writer misses the draft deadline, the piece will likely need to be pushed (see Section 7.3).

14. Recurring Meetings

Day	Time	Meeting	Who
Sunday	1:00 PM	Senior Staff	All section leaders/editors, paid staff
Sunday	2:00 PM	Full Staff	Every member of The Daily Gamecock
Sunday	2:30 PM	Opinion Section	Opinion writers and opinion leadership
Wednesday	5:00 PM	Senior Staff	All section leaders/editors, paid staff

15. Headline Writing (Opinion)

Opinion headlines **argue** — they do not report. The headline must convey WHY it matters and WHO is responsible. See **DG.Headlines** in the style guides folder for the full guide.

15.1. Seven Principles

Rule	Do	Don't
No colons	Write fluid, declarative sentences	"USC parking: students pay the price"
No false urgency	Opinions are timeless; skip temporal words	"just," "now," "recently"
No explainers	Deliver the verdict immediately	"Why USC's parking policy fails students"
Opinion as fact	State opinions as objective truths	"Students feel parking is unfair"
No names	Use roles/actions (unless iconic figure)	"John Smith's policy fails students"
Active blame	Name the actor	"Mistakes were made" (passive)
So what?	Predict future consequences	Only describing the present problem

15.2. Approved Headline Structures

15.2.1. Analysis Pieces

1. Dead/Over Declaration — "The era of X is dead"
2. Comparative Value — "X matters more than Y"
3. Action/Consequence — "A acts as / leads to B"
4. Inverse/Reframe — Flip the common narrative

15.2.2. Activism Pieces

1. "It Is Time" Ultimatum — for total overhauls
2. Mandate — use "must," not "should," for powerful entities
3. "A, Not B" Responsibility Shift — push blame up the ladder

16. Editing Tiers

Choose the appropriate level of intervention based on how much work the draft needs:

Tier	When to Use	What You Do
------	-------------	-------------

Level 1: Rewrite	Full	Draft needs complete re-construction	Rewrite while preserving the writer's research; ask them which original parts to keep
Level 2: Rewrite	Sectional	Specific sections are weak	Targeted fixes to problem areas only
Level 3: Pass	Comment	Draft is mostly solid	Strategic inline comments; writer retains full authorship

17. Source Verification & Statements

17.1. When You MUST Request a Statement

- Criticism or allegations against a person or institution
- Claims of negligence, incompetence, or discrimination
- Potentially harmful assertions affecting someone's reputation

17.2. Recording Requirements

Interview recordings **must** be sent to copydeskt dg@gmail.com with the following:

- Interviewee name (confirm spelling)
- Title/year
- Position/major

17.3. Attribution Rules

- Default is **on the record**. The Daily Gamecock does not accept “off the record” without editor approval.
- **Email interviews are not allowed** — phone or Zoom required.
- Email **statements** are accepted from universities and government only.
- Use “said” for attribution. Avoid “stated” or “mentioned.”

17.4. If a Source Doesn't Respond

- Follow up **once** with a polite reminder before your deadline.
- Try alternative channels (phone if email fails).
- Write: “did not respond to a request for comment” — **never** “refused to comment.”
- Typical response window: 48–72 hours. Don't delay indefinitely.

17.5. Source Quality (most to least reliable)

1. Government documents / official records
2. Peer-reviewed academic research

3. Established news organizations
4. Official institutional statements
5. Expert interviews
6. Personal interviews with affected individuals
7. Organizational websites
8. Verified social media accounts
9. Unverified social media / personal blogs

18. Article Structure

18.1. Target Word Count

- **Standard column (online)** — 700–900 words
- **Print piece** — 1,500–1,600 words

18.2. Anatomy of an Opinion Piece

18.2.1. Introduction

- **Lede** (1st paragraph): Strong, arguable statement. State the opinion, introduce the topic, convey significance.
- **Nutgraf** (2nd paragraph): Essential context in 75 words max. Answer who, when, where. Must appear within the first three paragraphs.

18.2.2. Body (in any order)

- **Diagnosis:** Layer the problem with data, statistics, quotes, anecdotes.
- **Prescription:** A solution (direct proposal), alternative (better path), or rationale (explain the flawed logic).
- **Counter-arguments:** Concede valid opposing points, then refute — explain why your argument is still stronger.

18.2.3. Closing (choose one or combine)

- **Conclusion:** Restate main point in new words + summarize key evidence.
- **Call-to-Action:** Tell readers what to do (vote, petition, contact, think differently).
- **Coda:** A final reflective thought or anecdote.

18.3. Subhead Rules

- First subhead after the lede must be **factual, not tonal**.
- Place subheads every **3–4 paragraphs**.
- Keep to **2–7 words**.
- Must reflect the content that follows.

19. AP Style Quick Reference

19.1. Dates

- Abbreviate months with dates: **Aug.** 15, 2024 (comma around year)
- Never abbreviate **March, May, June, July** when standing alone
- Ranges: **Oct.** 15–18
- Month + year only: **August** 2024 (no comma)

19.2. Names & Titles

- First reference: full name, title, credentials
- Subsequent references: last name only
- Student format: “Jane Doe, a third-year engineering student, said...”
- Never call a student a “major” (e.g., not “engineering major”)
- Capitalize formal titles before names, lowercase after
- Verify spelling via: (1) university directory, (2) LinkedIn + university bio, (3) ask the source directly

19.3. General

- Paragraphs: **1–4 sentences max**
- Periods go **inside** quotation marks
- Use “said” for attribution

19.4. Statements Hierarchy

Type	Example	Source Required?
Definitive	“USC is increasing housing prices”	Yes
Qualified	“It seems USC is increasing housing costs”	Not necessarily
Personal	“I think USC is increasing housing prices”	No (but discouraged)